



Hot Air Balloons



Did you see that big balloon, as it flew through the blue sky? Do you know that a hot air balloon is in fact a type of aircraft? And, do you know that the first people carrying flight technology was the hot air balloon?

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The history of the hot air balloon is important. In Ancient China, the first use of hot air to make objects fly was made with paper lanterns. These were sent into the air for signaling. The first hot air balloon flight with people on board was in the 1780s.

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The balloon on top is called an 'envelope'. It is usually made of nylon. It holds the hot air created by the heat from the burner. The burner makes an open flame. The fire gets fueled with propane.

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How does it work? The hot air inside the envelope has a lower density than the cooler air outside and this makes the balloon 'buoyant'. This means hot air is lighter than cool air. This makes it rise and carry up the balloon when the air inside is heated.

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Usually people stand in the basket. The basket is usually made of wicker. The top of the balloon has a vent. This allows the pilot to control the speed of the ascent and descent.

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Hot air balloon festivals are popular around the world. They are well known in Cappadocia (Turkey) and Luxor (Egypt).

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The festival pilots will fly in the morning and in the evening. Sometimes the balloons will be lit up against the night sky. Super! Hot air balloons are beautiful. Can you choose which one you like the most?

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